

Raining Incentives for the "Kisan"

Karz Mukti (Loan Waiver) - The UPA farmer's loan waiver package of Rs. 71,000 crore for entire country saw Maharashtra getting a share of Rs. 7,000 crore. It was disbursed to 34 lakh farmers who were defaulters unable to repay the loans. The highest number of beneficiaries - 1.52 million from the western Maharashtra region had loans of Rs. 39.8 billion, or about 50 per cent of the total package for the State, written off. The beneficiaries include 2.70 million farmers with land holdings below five acres and another 1.58 million with land



holdings of five acres and above. On the other hand, the State Government has intended to make budgetary provisions to extend economic benefits as incentives to regular loan repaying farmers.

Farm loans @ 6% - Rs.130 crore has been earmarked this financial year for the farmers. Farmers are to be given agricultural loans at the subsidised rate of interest of 6 per cent. The farmers who are taking loan up to Rs. 25,000 and repaying it in due time will be eligible for a 4 per cent subsidy. Those who are taking a loan of more than Rs. 25,000 upto Rs. 3 lakh will be getting 2 per cent subsidy.



Farmers' Package

- Big relief to farmers of suicide prone areas through effective implementation of Farmers' Package declared by Centre and State Government.



Maharashtra: Empowering Rural Women

Maharashtra is the only State where banks finance Women Self-Help Groups (SHGs) at a meager rate of 4 per cent. The 4 per cent interest replaces the existing 9-11 per cent. Cheaper loans would be a major boost to around 2.25 lakh women's Self-Help Groups operating in Maharashtra. Around 45,000 SHGs will get Rs. 50,000, 72,000 SHGs will get Rs. 1 lakh and 18,000 SHGs Rs. 2 lakh disbursement. These groups will be eligible for higher loans once they repay these loans on time.

- Historic decision of making available loan to Women Self-Help Groups at 4 per cent interest. New era of women development in rural areas has begun.
- Three lakh Self-Help Groups set up under various schemes, consolidating the base for women.
- Work of supplying nutritious food to anganwadis given to Self-Help Groups.
- Assistance to farmers and farm labours for their daughters marriage under *Shubhamangal Community Marriage Scheme*.
- Successful implementation of Anti Family Violence Act.
- Mahar Yojana* for destitute, widows and divorced women.

Also these loans are expected to motivate women and enhance their performance that would further ensure better returns and regular repayment of loans. The scheme is likely to benefit around 17 lakh women from rural areas and 1,42,218 SHGs. The aim is primarily to help these women have easier access to credit and help improve their livelihood.

The State Government has undertaken a new scheme called 'Navsanjivan' to ensure prenatal registration of pregnant women, regular checking of their health and providing them with help in the form of medicines. Under this scheme 'Matrutva Anudan' is given to women with maximum 3 children. This scheme is being implemented in 15 tribal districts like Thane, Nashik, Nadurbar, Amravati, Raigad, Gadchiroli, Ahmednagar, Dhule, Jalgaon, Pune, Nanded, Yavatmal, Gondia, Chandrapur and Nagpur. This 'Matrutva Anudan' scheme is a cash benefit of Rs. 400 and medicines worth Rs. 400. The funds for this scheme are made available under the Tribal Welfare Programme.